

TRAINING SPECIFIC

TIM LEES



✓ EXPECTATION TO EXPERTISE

✓ SESSIONS FOR SUCCESS

✓ BUILDING BESPOKE PERSONAL PROGRAMMES



TRAINING SPECIFIC
REACH YOUR TRUE POTENTIAL

This book aims to provide information on the core principles of individual development and ideas of how to create these through training. It would be unwieldy to list all the technical, tactical, physical and psychological returns for each individual session listed in the latter section of this book. Instead, the core principles of each specific topic are noted. Furthermore, the sessions describe setups and provide suggestions without going into in specific detail. Each player is different, and thus the focus of the exercise should be adapted to the personality and individual identity of the player.

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Author

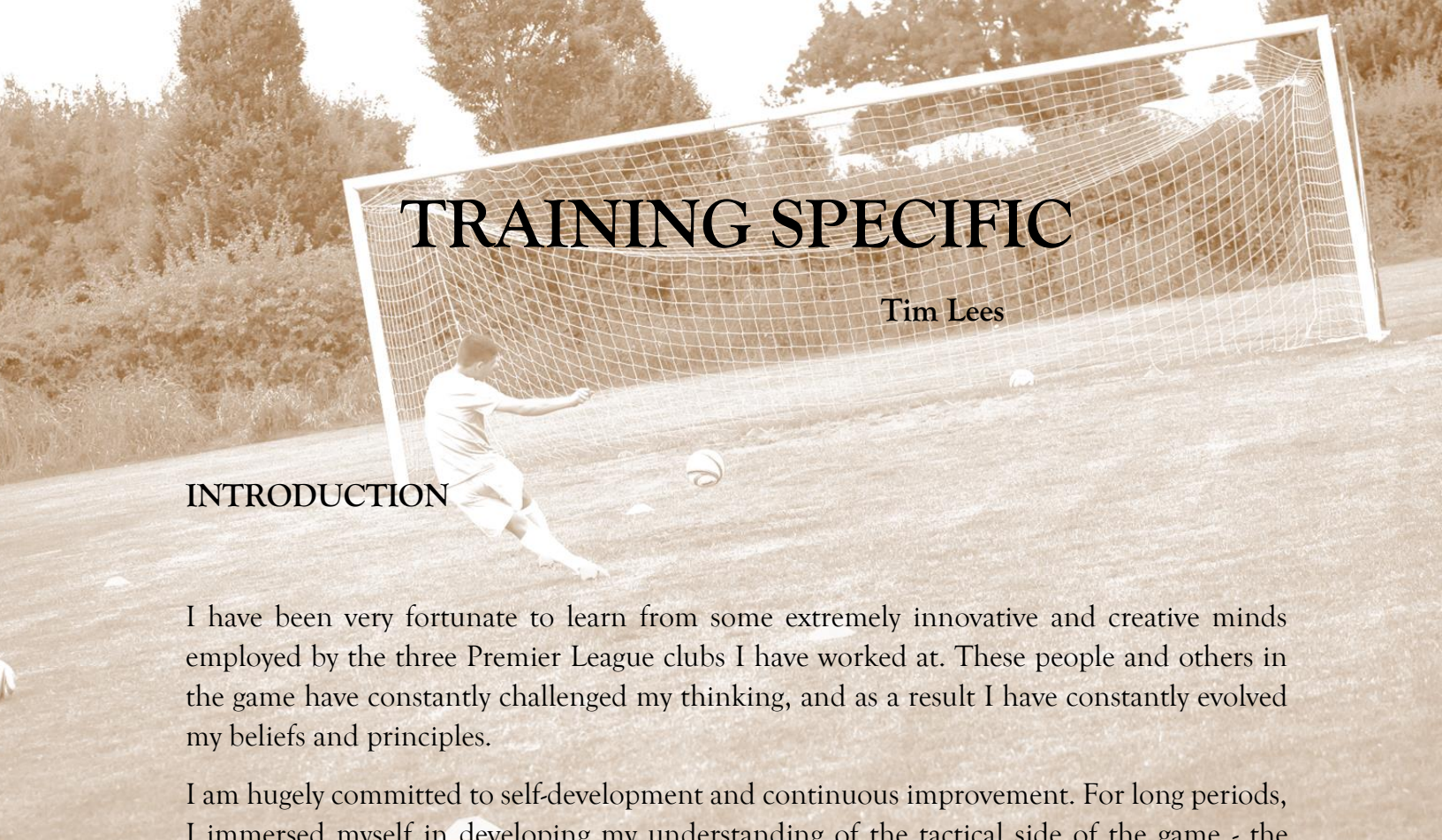
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TRAINING SPECIFIC

Tim Lees

INTRODUCTION

I have been very fortunate to learn from some extremely innovative and creative minds employed by the three Premier League clubs I have worked at. These people and others in the game have constantly challenged my thinking, and as a result I have constantly evolved my beliefs and principles.

I am hugely committed to self-development and continuous improvement. For long periods, I immersed myself in developing my understanding of the tactical side of the game - the collective systems, formations, triggers, movements, patterns and principles. However, my core belief, the consistent undercurrent, has always been to instill proficiency in technique and the promotion of unpredictability in players.

In and away from football, I am fascinated by the mavericks, the unorthodox and the creative. I am enthralled by beauty, artistry and magic. I take inspiration from the purple cow in the field.

As a result, individual development is an area of football that I feel is frequently misunderstood, undervalued and underused. There are some truly brilliant coaches and clubs who value it, but probably not enough.

This book attempts to exhibit my own ideas on how to promote, enhance and develop the individualistic potentials and qualities of every player. The descriptions and explanations have coaches, parents and players in mind.

I hope you find the book thought provoking if nothing else.

I genuinely enjoyed putting this one together...

Tim Lees

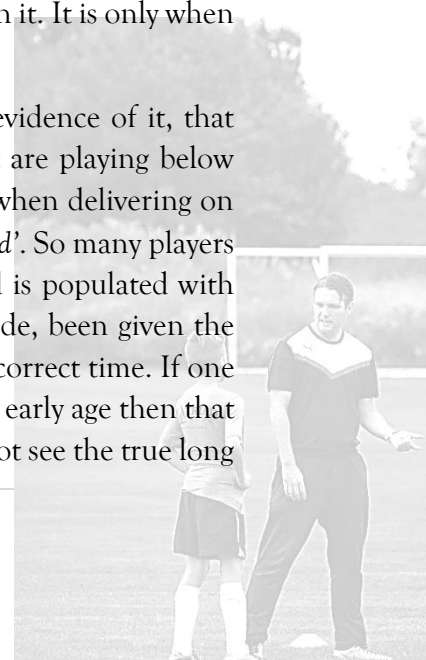


PART ONE: PLANTING THE SEEDS

**Throughout the book where I talk of the “player” I have then used “him” as the next reference. This is for ease of reading and to avoid the grammatical error of the plural “their”. It is not a slight on the many females who, I hope, read the book and coach, support or play our wonderful game.*

There is a consistent debate amongst the worldwide footballing community at all levels about **results v development** at youth levels. Whilst each reader will understandably adopt a view that is particular and pertinent to him/herself on that argument, what is irrefutable is that every coach has an incredible amount of influence and responsibility when working with young people. The role of the coach, regardless of his or her personal philosophy or beliefs, is to ensure that each player completely maximises their potential. Our job is to squeeze every drop of juice from the orange. However, this is much easier said than done. Football is a random and variable invasion game, therefore it is hard to objectively measure the true efficiency of development methods and coaching. Players can come through youth systems despite of the programme, not because of it, but the best systems ensure that players do come through as a result of it. Football is not a technology company nor subject to scientific method; you cannot put a youth player through a specific production programme then assess where you made errors and tweak its final design. You cannot track whether you reached a player’s full optimal potential. The same player never goes through the system twice, which unfortunately (or fortunately for the dinosaurs) hides some of the prehistoric methods that some youth leaders still hide behind. In effect, unless someone at the top is holding staff accountable and really cares about maximising development, you can coach badly and get away with it. It is only when you watch the true masters of their craft at work, then you know where you are.

It is my personal opinion, and I have a tremendous amount of observational evidence of it, that there is so much untapped potential out there. There are so many players that are playing below their level. John McDermott, Tottenham’s Academy Manager, uses a great line when delivering on the youth award; ‘*there is nothing more abundant than unsuccessful men who are talented*’. So many players underachieve due to the lack of guidance and coaching. Non-league in England is populated with players that could have played at a much higher level had they shown the attitude, been given the right coaching, been in the right programme or had the right opportunity at the correct time. If one thinks that the Premier League is a result of the best potential developed from an early age then that is a big mistake. Many academies frequently give up on players too early and do not see the true long



term potential. Instead, they see problems, holes and deficiencies and not solutions. It has generally become second nature in the professional game for coaches to see the reasons a player cannot play a high level rather than the reasons that they can. Long term potential does not always look how we would 'like' it to and it is not always obvious. There are so many players 'nailed on' (as they say) at under 9s that are not even playing the game at u16s, just as there are so many players playing elite level first team that were not the best players at under 13s. Players are all on unique journeys, are all on different paths and need different things at different times; no two players are the same. The job of youth coaches is to try to bring the very best out of each player but this message often gets lost due to numerous factors that will be discussed in this book. The following excerpt is the 'job description' that I personally give to staff ensuring there are no grey areas in terms of their accountability and responsibility:

THE ROLE

Our job is to produce elite players, that by 18-23 years of age, can play in any respective team, philosophy or country. The collective style will be optimised to bring out the best in the players, but the job is not to produce a specific squad of players or team. The team doesn't make its debut together (Cruyff) and players will come and go throughout the journey. Leave your ego at the door, it's not about this weekend.

UNDERSTAND THE JOURNEY

If a player comes into us at u8 he could have over ten years with us. This weekend is not the concern. Always remember that, regardless of where you and the player are on that journey. Are players getting through our system despite or because of what we can provide? Are we enhancing what they bring to us?

WHAT TO EXPECT ON THE JOURNEY

Many dips. This is one of the only guarantees. No player every born was the best player in every single session and game. This journey will have extreme highs, extreme lows, growth spurts, problems at school and parental issues. There will times where the player will think we have been too hard on him, times where he will have teammates who move on/get called up, times of jealousy, times of anger. The player will deal with rejection, will want to play at a higher level and will be introduced to a new world (agents, clubs etc.). All of these issues will cause players to waiver and have low moments. We must always see the long term picture and not take snapshots.

*****THE CONNECTION*****

Do the players have a reason to get excited every time they walk through those training ground gates?

Do we have staff that ignite them and they believe in? Knowledge is redundant if they don't want to go with you

Inspire them with who you are first. Your personality is the key, not knowledge

For players to fulfil their true potential, a specific environment (on a daily consistent basis) is paramount. Regardless of the level, be it grassroots, professional or international, the support network around the player can be the differentiating variable that shapes the level that they can/will progress to. The 'environment' and 'support structure' can be split into many sections. When

working with staff, I generally try to ensure we are delivering the highest quality in the following areas:

1) THE PLAYERS

- Recruit the best potential ('potential' is a separate presentation for staff)

2) THE STAFF

- Nurture the best people to work with the players through collective and consistent education. Stay in touch with the modern game and try to use educated data to assess what the future game will look like technically, tactically, physically and psychologically. Recruit people who will push and challenge you, not robots who do what you say.
- Employ engaging, passionate coaches that players will follow. These are people who can really 'ignite' players. Again, knowledge is not as important as personality to ignite. Knowledge without the right personality is inefficiency.

3) THE PLACE

- Create a learning environment that promotes excellence in every way, every day.
- Methodology. We have to prepare players for the modern game, always recognising the various styles of play that they may find themselves playing in. We can NEVER allow them to leave the club and say 'sorry we do it this way at ...so I cannot adapt'
 - Playing style (has to be conducive for elite talent)
- Individual work and plans are key to improvement and reaching the elite/expert level
 - Inspiring, motivational and role models

4) THE SESSIONS

- Maximise contact hours whilst not being obsessed with it (10,000 is statistically proven as inaccurate)
- Encourage and challenge home practice and investment continually on and off the field

5) THE PARTICIPATION

- Games programme has to be of relevant level and against varied opposition with different levels of technique, pitches, competition(s) etc. Playing against a similar level of opponent in terms of style will not prepare players realistically
 - Opportunities to play against best and in competitions where they have to win at times
 - Competitive. Trialist's mentality everyday

6) THE PATHWAY

- Provide players with a pathway to succeed. Are they at a club where their motivation is consistently high as they know opportunity is possible? Or is the goal never in touching distance?

7) THE NETWORK

- Give players the best support network possible: Nutrition, diet, S & C, psychology, individual programmes

The following excerpt is a small principle based section that I took from Modern Soccer Coach book. I refer to this on a regular basis.

BE AVAILABLE

Your accessibility and receptiveness can strongly influence a player's decision to connect with you. You should take the lead and not wait for players to approach you first. A coach can be intimidating. When you step forward and initiate conversation, you show you care and the impact will be greater. It has to be genuine though.

ALWAYS USE NAMES

Really simple principle. When they arrive at any game or session, greet them with eye contact, a smile and 'good morning/afternoon (first name)'. It lets your players know you are happy they are there and is a positive way to start the activity.

TAKE A GENUINE INTEREST

A key way to lay the foundations is to take a genuine interest in the player. It can be as simple as asking about family life and then remembering things that are important to them. LISTEN to the answers. Honesty, trustworthy and openness are great traits to have – although they are rare in football!

SHOW ENTHUSIASM

Look for positive things to say on a daily basis. No matter how outgoing they are, a lot of players suffer from confidence on a daily basis. It's an alpha male environment, a survival of the fittest and it breeds a lot of insecurity and uncertainty. Their daily job is to wear the mask and not show feelings or weakness. I had this as a young player. Whilst constructive criticism has its place, do it in a manner that does not offend the player – unless the situations really needs it.

HAVE SOME FUN

I personally try to start all sessions off with a fun warm up which changes on a daily basis. Training can become monotonous and the best environments are full of laughs and smiles at the right times. If a player likes being there he will commit more to it. Sarcasm can be misunderstood so choose your humour wisely.

MIX UP ROUTINES

When we are in our comfort zone we tend to do things that are easy and cause little friction. When you mix things up, you force yourself to use the skills of old fashioned relationship building. Spend time in different environments and settings. Things like a text message or phone call may seem small but goes a long way.

LISTEN

Some of the best coaches I know cannot listen properly. It often comes back to ego and insecurity. Coaches are programmed to lecture and dictate – it is habit. Players love to share their experiences of the game and their opinions when you ask.

GAIN TRUST

It takes a long time to build but a short time to lose. It is related that 50% of relationships falter due to trust failure. Consistency is key here. Players need to know they can count on you to reward them at the right times but also you will clamp down when you need to make them accountable, from this, trust builds. Mauricio Pochettino says '*deep down, players do not want lunatics running the asylum. They want order.*' You lose trust by telling them positive things all the time.

Once the environment is optimised and built into the DNA of coaching staff, a player's development is influenced in ways that can be classed into two main categories: The COLLECTIVE and INDIVIDUAL.

Is the player playing in a COLLECTIVE style that is conducive to getting repetitions of what that player needs? In terms of the INDIVIDUAL methodology, developing a player can be split into various sections. Each position has a series of specific attributes that are essential for a player to possess, in order to be effective. We cannot leave it to chance that players will develop these specific skills through generic sessions and must allocate time to honing them. Many players will change positions throughout their youth career. A high percentage of centre backs playing at the highest level were playing in forward positions in the pitch when they were younger. Very rarely could you speak to a centre back playing in the Premier League, who had been playing in that position in his youth. Players tend to move backwards. Generally, in youth ages, centre backs are stoppers; technically the least proficient but physically the strongest. As football reaches professional ages, their technical and physical deficiencies are exposed more and they often get released. Players playing higher who cannot quite cut it retreat down the pitch. If you have been playing higher up the field as a youth player, generally you have a high technical ability and physical profile. You may have fallen slightly short in some areas but now the game is in front of you as a centre back, it is much easier than the chaos you have been playing in. The techniques and skillset you have developed over years become transferable at the back; you just need to learn the tactical concepts collectively and master 1v1 defending. This process is much easier than trying to give an immobile, technically poor player all of the things they need. For many reasons, every player cannot be pigeon-holed at a young age into one specific position, however, from 12 years onwards we can begin to see where players may fall with their profiles. An elite 1v1 dribbler will likely play wide or drop as a full back. An elite passer/controller will likely play central midfield. An elite twisting/turning creator will play off the front somewhere. An elite finisher will likely play as a striker etc. We can begin to give players what they need, the further and deeper they go into the 11v11 format. Before this, in my opinion, you are guessing if you say you know what position an under 7-11 will end up being.

PARETO'S PRINCIPLE

Pareto was an Italian economist who observed that 80% of effects come from 20% of causes. For example, in business often 80% of sales come from 20% of clients. Thus, rather than teaching a centre back all 100% of techniques required for an outfield player (dribbling, shooting, crossing etc) and expecting a vast improvement, we are better teaching them the 20% of techniques – the ones that are specific for their position (e.g. heading, tackling, blocking) We can expect 80% better results this way. A few ideas:

- Dedicate time to position specific sessions
- Highlight demands from specific positions when coaching generic sessions

- Allow players to observe examples of good practice in their position (training with older ages, watching pros, video, top level games etc.)
- Use all coaches within the session effectively
- Ensure players play in relevant roles within sessions
- Give position specific feedback to individuals continually

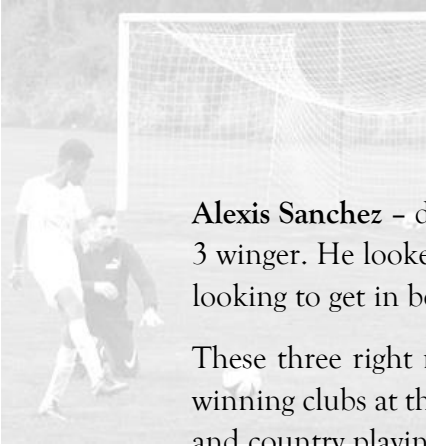
MAKING YOUR STRENGTHS STRONGER

The best players in the world, the platinum players worth millions, still continue to work every day on specifics for them. In fact, the elite level is arguably more specific than ever before. The examples are endless at every pro club in the world. However, there is a common myth amongst many academy prospects that the top players are elite and do not continue to work on their strengths. When asked about who their favourite coach is, the majority of professional players will base their selection on coaches or managers who continue to develop or care for them. Conversely, they will name their least favourite managers as those who stopped developing them. The worst youth coaches become obsessed with tactical development (winning) and forget about the person (developing). The very elite continue to develop individuals within their collective philosophy whilst building the game model and style of play. Cristiano Ronaldo at Madrid frequently works on finishing exercises from certain areas of the box to improve his individual efficiency, Phillipe Coutinho watches videos of Ronaldinho to improve the way he shifts his body in 1v1 situations and Andres Iniesta works on his efficiency in sliding people in behind in the final third. Top players want to improve their individual efficiency in whatever it is they are asked to excel in; elite centre backs want clean sheets, creative midfielders want higher assists, efficient defensive midfielders want a higher pass completion into higher lines and world class strikers want higher conversion percentages; the best ones are all obsessed with being better on a daily basis. This is their daily ritual. Thus, referring back to Pareto's principle, rather than a winger working on lots of requirements (defending 1v1, heading, dribbling, shooting, crossing, passing etc) and expecting a vast improvement come 3pm on a Saturday, we are better teaching them the 20% of the techniques that they will need in the game. We can expect 80% better results by doing this but in order to achieve maximum development, the player/coach must delve into another, deeper layer. Let's take right midfield as a positional example. In this one position the technical and tactical profile could change depending on the player, system, style, club, league and manager.

If we use the most famous right midfielders of recent times:

Beckham – rarely dribbled 1v1, not particularly skilful or efficient in going past full backs, not particularly quick to dominate his opponent in behind without the ball but was an outstanding striker of the ball; thus his 'elite' strength was delivering consistently from wide areas.

Arjen Robben – left footed right winger who cuts inside frequently and plays inverted. He is very efficient from that half space channel in creating and scoring off the dribble. Destroys full backs 1v1.



Alexis Sanchez – during his Barcelona times he frequently played off the right as an old school 4-3-3 winger. He looked to dominate his opponent with the ball but constantly played on the shoulder looking to get in behind.

These three right midfielders played at the same level internationally and for Champions League winning clubs at the highest attainable standard. They all had/have established long careers for club and country playing the same position but all have completely different profiles and strengths. As a coach or manager, you would label all three as elite in their youth days but would plan individual programmes completely differently to bring out their strengths. You would be equally happy to have any of them your team. Therefore, it is too simplistic and general to teach ‘positions’ the same techniques and is illogical to have a profile for a specific position.

What are the implications when working individually with players?

A coach with good intentions but an inflated ego can actually do more damage than good working with a young player. If a player has a weakness that is glaring then it’s likely that it will never become his strength no matter how many hours he dedicates to it. One has to also consider the relevance of that weakness, in terms of priority for that player. For example, a player who is in the team as a target man to hold the ball up with his back to goal does not need to spend countless hours prioritising movements to run in behind; rather, work on receiving techniques with pressure behind. Does he need to practice any movement in behind? Of course, but he needs emphasis and repetitions on what his personality and identity bring to the team. One can often see elite sessions from Premier League first team to top academy setups, where players go long periods working on generic skills rather than consistently developing the specific demands of their own game. Elite level football is not one size fits all yet it is often treated that way. Let’s use an example, as a very generic and broad summary. A common session structure throughout world football is:

-Boxes/rondos as a warm up

-Small sided possession as a base (rondos, possession games, breakouts etc)

-Shape work as a core element (phases, SSGs, 11v11’s etc, set pieces, match prep)

-Finishing/matches/tournament

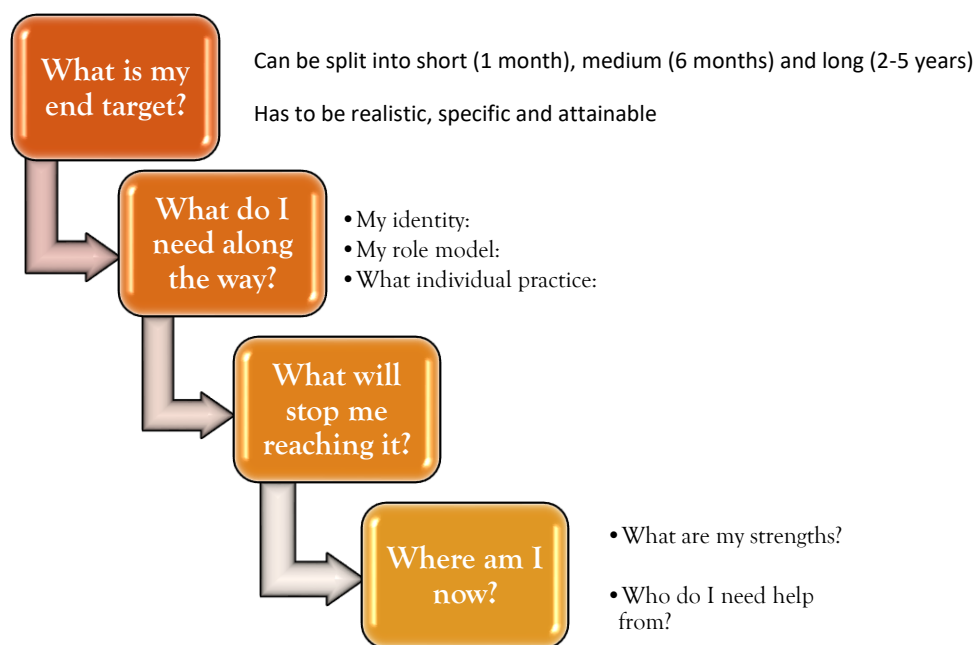
The demands of each player could be broken down positionally and specifically into thousands of sub categories but in this generic session structure, a centre back may have gone through the session having defended 1v1 less than a dozen times, a midfielder may have played only in tight areas when he needs bigger spaces come the weekend and a striker may have felt the back of the net on minimal occasions. Therefore, how are the players expected to improve individually with this structure in place on a consistent basis? This structure quickly becomes routine, especially in the middle of a season when teams are on the grind every day. How can a coach and manager judge a player’s improvement or development against criteria that they are not consistently working on? It’s the equivalent to being at university and studying for a masters degree on a topic that will not feature on the final exam.

FOR PLAYERS: IT'S YOUR PLAN: YOU TAKE CONTROL AND DRIVE IT



As a player, you are dispensable. Unfortunately it's true, regardless of the level. Not every coach will care for you and not every coach will spend time focusing on your individual plan, so YOU must take control of it. Every player has a huge influence on his own personal development. Often, players just need guidance and direction. It has to be the player's plan and he has to drive it. No one will be as passionate about a player developing more than the player himself but often personal development is overlooked. A coach can influence

this if the player does not have a clear identity or path. There will be more buy-in from the player if he understands his plan, why they are doing it and what it will achieve. If it's being dictated by the coach then it is less sustainable long term. Asking the right questions is vital and this plan below is a format I like to go through consistently with the players:



At the beginning of each season I sit down with each player and go through this plan. The player fills out the details so he has accountability. I take a copy but the original is for him to look at on a regular basis. We discuss the answers and I may influence with certain questions but the player comes up with the plan, not me. Each conversation is a minimum half hour where I can really get to understand what motivates the player and what his personality is. Once I understand this, it helps us both to reach optimum potential. This is a key part of not only understanding the player but building trust and a genuine relationship.

Jim Collins' book *Good To Great*, highlights the 'Hedgehog Theory' which can be applied to football. He speaks about how the fox is constantly hunting the hedgehog in numerous ways to catch it. In order to capture his prey he hides, he pounces, he slowly approaches, he sprints, he changes his angle, he comes out at different times but ultimately none of these techniques ever work. The hedgehog has become a master of one thing; self-defence. He curls up in a ball and when his spikes come out he cannot be penetrated. Whilst the fox is good at a lot of things, the hedgehog masters what he needs to. To become the best at something, you need to be an expert. Every single player will have weaknesses - the most elite of all time have glaringly obvious ones. But they all have extreme strengths. I constantly challenge players to ask themselves:

-What is it that I am elite at?

-What reason am I giving the manager/coach to put me in the team?

-If I am in bad form do I have a quality that will keep me in?

-What do I offer the team that no one else can?

-When I am at my best, what exactly do I look like?

-Do I know what an elite player in my position/identity looks like?

-What is my identity as a player?

-What attribute is my 9 out of 10 ('superpower' for young!) as a player?

Every coach has a responsibility to be asking players these questions on a daily basis. Once the coach has built a relationship enough to where the player trusts that they can develop them, true development flourishes. The coach should be consistently giving feedback to players based around their identity. It has to become a day to day ritual rather than an inconsistent reminder. It is pointless in establishing a plan with the player and then not working towards it consistently. That's a process and not functional - there is enough of that going on with EPPP.

England international Dele Alli speaks about the staff at MK Dons throughout his youth career and how they continually encouraged his creativity. He knew creativity was his 8 out of 10 and he did not want to focus on less relevant areas of his game at which point his creativity would drop to a 6. The environment continually challenged him to be creative and hold this as his identity.

Once the player understands himself and what he needs to be elite at, he can then figure out exactly where he needs help. Rene Mulensteen was first team individual coach at Manchester United for many years and talks about how he began his conversations with players '*I think I have something that we can add to your game*'. But in order to get buy-in from players, the individual has to know what his strong areas are. Once he has his own plan and he is driving it, the coach is merely prompting, promoting and enhancing. Players need to continually work on their weaknesses to ensure they do not stand out but focusing on their strengths and making them stronger is the key to developing. The specific areas that players invest their time is absolutely imperative in individual development. If the hard work is in the wrong places then the output will be low. This, in turn, impacts motivation.

Any coach can run generic positional or technical sessions but the truly great coaches really put the player's game under microscope and enhances his qualities. Make the sessions for the players. Working on weaknesses that rarely get exposed to get small percentage gains is not nearly as efficient as developing the player's frequently required attribute(s). It all begins with the athlete understanding himself: what does he stand for? What values and principles does he live by? What does he enjoy? What motivates him? What makes him unique? I took the following excerpt from a leadership book that analysed hundreds of 'elite level' athletes that all had a daily focus on self-development and I feel this is very important for players:

SKILLS

Listen and take advice
Develop and make use of support network
Independent learners
Take feedback well and welcome it
Accept inevitable negativity from people
Communicate with management (they are not your generation)
Resist peer pressure
Plan your goal and break it down
Able to keep highs down and lows up

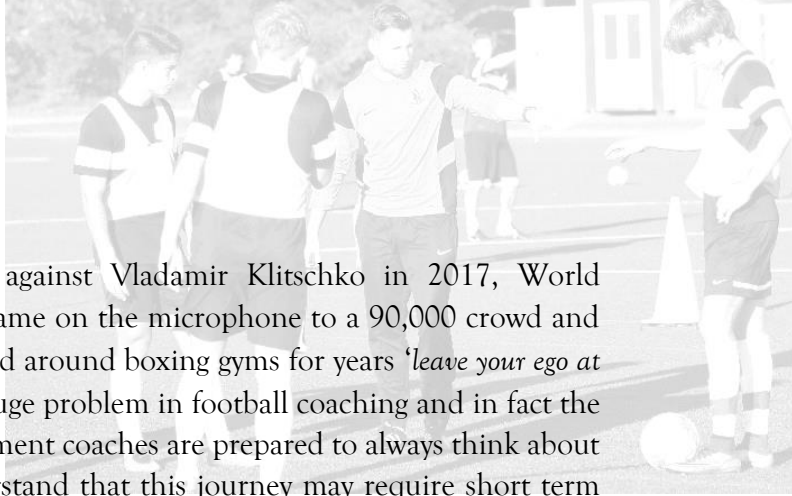
TRAITS

Value learning on and off field
Self-discipline
Perseverance
Cope with pressure
Passion
Have other responsibilities outside the game
Be assured and confident
Take responsibility for all actions
Ask for help!
Risk takers

These traits were found to be consistent amongst high level performers. I personally believe that some of these variables contribute hugely to those players who are elite at nine years of age and then fall off the wagon later. The psychological profile of the child is a huge factor in their development. Their personality and mentality can undoubtedly be developed and moulded in the right environment but from my experience, you can see whether these traits are prevalent from a young age. Put a group of under 9's in a repetitive technical practice and you can see immediately the players who are motivated to be better, the ones who love the game, those who have the desire to improve and the resilience to repetition. Can you tell who the best players will be in ten years? No chance, but you can see the personalities and the mentalities of the players. With this in mind, I am a big believer that recruitment in very young ages (8-11) should not be based solely on technique but on personality traits. Remember, a club has ten years with a child for four days a week in an elite environment. A good coach can develop a tactical style of play and improve techniques in this period, but only if the mentality of the player is right. The Ski Slope theory (detailed later on in this book) explains this in detail.

Ego

After his historic victory at Wembley Stadium against Vladamir Klitschko in 2017, World Heavyweight Boxing Champion Anthony Joshua came on the microphone to a 90,000 crowd and began his speech with a great phrase that has echoed around boxing gyms for years *'leave your ego at the door when you enter this game'*. Ego; it really is a huge problem in football coaching and in fact the game is rotten to the core with it. The best development coaches are prepared to always think about what is best for the player(s) long term, and understand that this journey may require short term pain for long term gain. For example, an under 11 centre back may need to work on his 1v1 defending techniques. If the team always defend with an overload (often seen 2v1 at the back) then this does the polar opposite to what he needs. He can press with cover and if he covers then his teammate defends the 1v1 – this scenario does not develop what he needs. In order to improve the player, the coach may ask his team to defend 1v1 in attacking balance, meaning that when the ball is in the opponents' half he asks other players to adopt higher positions, thus exposing the centre back isolated 1v1. This will provide him with more 1v1 scenarios aerially, on the ground, pressure behind, stopping, twisting and turning, physical connection with various styles of opponents, attacker dribbling etc. As a result of deploying this strategy, the team will inevitably concede more goals and look more open. To people on the side who do not understand long term development (unfortunately this is a high percentage) this will look naive and poor coaching. However, this is proper coaching. Any coach with basic knowledge and observational skills can manipulate a youth game tactically to achieve results. The real coaches provide the players with what they need rather than focusing purely on the scoreline.



IF YOU GET THE PROCESS RIGHT THEN THE OUTCOME WILL OFTEN TAKE CARE OF ITSELF

MARGINAL GAINS CLOCK

As discussed, players having accountability and responsibility for their own plan is imperative to long term success. Short term success can be achieved through dictating to the athlete but to truly make a long term impact, the player has to believe in it. He has to really know himself and his identity and be willing to sacrifice every day to build towards improvement. Balancing physical periodisation (for injury prevention) with additional work (to improve), needs specific planning and attention for the athlete, particularly in the teen years. Some players will just work and work which increases likelihood of injury. The specific areas that players can look to create marginal gains with their individual plans are:

10 MINUTE RULE



I learned this principle at Liverpool and it not only develops players from an individual point of view but also optimises psychological focus for a session. The normal practice for players of most ages and levels is to turn up to the pitch after prehab/activation/physical warm up with the S & C staff and take part in a version of a rondo. Now, rather than playing 1-5 yard, non-directional, non-functional, passes for 15 minutes where often the main objective is to embarrass the player(s) in the middle, employ what is known as **the 10**

minute rule. Here, every player works for 10 minutes on something specific they need that enhances and develops their identity. This should ideally not be as generic as working on your weaker foot, centre backs heading, midfielders passing and strikers finishing. It must be specific, for example a full back working on footwork patterns to shift his feet and twist his hips to defend efficiently in 1v1 situations against an opponent that he struggles with. If players invest in 10 minutes then this may not seem a lot. Multiplied by the four sessions they do that week, however, and they have worked for 40 minutes on improving a strength and become elite at what is required of them. That then equates to over two and a half hours a month and over twenty six and a half hours a season. With focused practice, a player now has over twenty six and a half hours of practice in one season dedicated to one strength; merely by substituting nutmegging the coach in a rondo for a bit of concentrated work.

MAKE SURE THAT YOU HAVE A STRENGTH THAT GETS YOU IN THE TEAM AND YOUR WEAKNESSES
DON'T GET YOU OUT OF IT

AFTER SESSIONS

This figure then doubles to over fifty three hours a season by having lunch ten minutes later and working after the session for ten minutes.

WITHIN SESSIONS

A few small observations and suggestions for marginal gains:

Observe the number of times you see elite level sessions with coaching staff standing together for long periods. This is time lost. Assistants could be taking players out working one to one or working throughout the game. It may not seem it for that individual session but working on honed skills with specific, focused practice consistently reaps inevitable rewards

Individual Development cannot just be a one off, it has to be consistent. The number of places throughout the world that they start off the season in the summer working individually then come

December when it's cold and raining, the focus now is on results and the consistency has long gone. The 'grind' gets them! You see the strikers staying behind doing finishing now and again but it's easier to go inside. Stay with them, it makes a difference.

-It has to be measurable. Record data, challenge players and continue to demand more. Relate their stats to the game - specificity

-As a coach it is very easy to become obsessed with tactical and collective responsibilities. It's the easiest way of influencing results and getting short term gains. Mick Beale at Liverpool taught me a great concept that he uses every single session – **what did I do for my top players today?** It is a very simple concept but one that a high percentage of coaches forget. It becomes all about the shape, the style, the units, the cohesion, the result – collective principles. I have incorporated a box on my session plans purely dedicated to individual players and what I am doing for them every session. This may be working individually within collective activities, standing next to a player in the 11v11 and talking them through scenarios, video work; it doesn't always have to be pulling players out for one to ones.

-Employ an Individual Development Coach. Every single club should have one of these. Working with Pepijn Lijnders at Liverpool was an education for me in developing players individually. He had previously worked in this role at Porto which had seen dozens of youth prospects move on for millions of euros. The IDC is responsible for building and maintaining the technical base in players whilst also working on position specific exercises to develop efficiency. Individual outplaying techniques in every position are absolutely imperative in the future game. If players do not work on these every week then the technical foundation will slowly regress.

AT HOME

As coaches, we must encourage, promote and stimulate players to invest in themselves away from training. Again, the player has to have the self-sacrifice and self-motivation to do so alone. Coaches can spark this through video, encouraging development areas, having role models to aspire to, etc. The best players never stop learning and developing. Phillipe Coutinho was interviewed recently and spoke about how he spends time studying Ronaldinho on Youtube to watch how he simulates his use of his shoulders and hips to outplay opponents with the defender in front. Bear in mind that this is a Champions League player who is an international and worth over £120m and could probably retire now and be financially stable for the rest of his life. If it's good enough for him then it's good enough for youth players.

Players should be watching the games from a tactical point of view. All young players should have a role model in their POSITION that matches their IDENTITY. The amount of times I ask an elite youth player who he is watching and the answer often has absolutely no correlation to his own personal needs. Young players are great, in fact outstanding, at practising badly but without knowing. Their intention is often right but they do not work smartly. I frequently look outside my office at the training ground in a morning and am made up to see the young players come in alone to practise. Then my enthusiasm is burst when I see them practising free kicks yet they don't take them on a

weekend! It happens in so many areas; I speak to the centre back who has Messi as his role model, or the defensively minded midfielder working on his finishing or the modern day centre back who never wants to work on his defending. Players need guidance, they need help and they need support continually. This only comes through building trust and respect but stepping in at the right times is imperative. Contrary to modern popularity and research, merely playing the game does not lead to elite development. Child led activities have huge benefits but these alone will not produce elite talent. Just putting players in a game and hoping that they find the answers is not efficient as a sole method of learning. If it did then the millions of players playing in five a side kick abouts worldwide several times a week would be premier league players. I love giving players responsibility and creating independent thinkers who can problem solve, but those developers who say they just put players in a game and they figured it out themselves, are wrong. Those players were going to be elite any way. For example, a winger who does not know how to create space for himself individually needs help and guidance from the coach. If a coach sets up an individual practice where the player has to dominate an opponent or mannequin to build the individual movement patterns prior to receiving, then that player will master movement faster than he would just playing a game with no guidance. The expert coach uses his experience (knowing the demands of the elite level) to enhance the individual (player does not know the significance of dominating his opponent without the ball). We cannot leave to chance that players will develop elite level requirements if they are not worked on consistently.



MUCH GOOD WORK IS LOST FOR THE LACK OF A LITTLE MORE

Edward H Harriman

I really like the picture below which reproduces a letter from Dean Smith to Michael Jordan (greatest basketballer of all time). Smith was Jordan's coach in his college years and the letter shows specificity, the breakdown of technical requirements and tactical elements to improve. It's a great example that highlights the importance of continual feedback from an individual point of view whilst adding in accountability through objectivity.

May 17, 1983

Mr. Michael Jordan
UNC Basketball Office
Chapel Hill, NC 27514

Dear Michael:

I am writing to list areas of basketball on which you should seek improvement this summer. In our last conversation in the office, we discussed these but thought it would be best to put them down in writing.

1. Shoot the ball the same way each time, the same arc.
2. Get your ritual on the foul shot; ~~going~~ ^{going} up on toes and extending. Don't fade back with your body.
3. In pick-up games, try to be a point guard, working on your dribbling and starting the ball low. Also, try to have more assists than turnovers.
4. Work on quick ball fakes and then bounce pass inside.
5. Work on busting out on the dribble from a rebound and making the play from the other end.
6. Continue work on the correct pivot foot.
7. Defensively keep working on the habits you now have and you will get even better.
8. Don't always reach for the ball but contain your man. You can't steal the ball all the time!

Michael, if you do improve on these items we mentioned, you will be a much better basketball player and, consequently, our team should be better and have a chance to win it all in Seattle next year. In your daydreaming, picture us winning it all in Seattle!

Warmest regards.

Most sincerely,

Dean E. Smith

D

In summary, every player needs to know his specific plan as below:

- 1) Know myself (what is elite about me?) What player am I going to be?
- 2) What is my daily plan to get there? Who am I watching? What types of practice am I doing every day?
- 3) Have I collated all of the information about the level I want to get to in microscopic detail? Technical, tactical, physical, psychological
- 4) Looking at this detail, what is going to stop me getting there? What glaring hurdle is in my way for my position and identity?
- 5) What areas am I going to improve every day? (on field, recovery methods, psychology, S&C, nutrition, self-analysis, role model(s), support structure, off field support/environment, recruit/talk to anyone specific who can enhance)

The plan needs to be put under the microscope to really enhance development. The following provides some examples of proper analysis:

-Assess your game. Where do things usually fall apart? When do you tend to lose form in the season or games? When do you lose motivation? Do you adjust playing next to different people? Are there certain styles of play that you struggle with? Are there certain opponents you struggle to play against?

-Body language. Look at body posture and see how it affects your game. On video do you have your head up at certain stages or head down? Negative look or positive look?

-Pregame: Rituals? Music? Routines? Food? Pumped up or relaxed? Superstitious?

-Physical preparation. Workout plan? S & C? Specific warm up needed? Yoga?

-Psychological anxiety. Get clear with your fears. Be ready to face them and move towards them, not away from them. Don't run from challenges as it becomes habitual in young players on and off the field.

TALENT DOES NOT ALWAYS LOOK HOW WE WANT IT TO

In terms of measuring individual development, professional clubs all have different objective analysis models which are predominantly based on various playing statistics, physical tests and independent key performance indicators. Without breaking these down, it is imperative to always remember that each player is on their own unique journey and the blueprint is not the same for everyone. Each player needs managing differently and this will never be a purely objective analysis as there are too many variable factors that come into play. Let's have a look at some current players. Lukaku was physically elite from an early age, Messi was on growth hormones as a child, Harry Kane finished bottom on all physical tests in his age group at Spurs one year out from a scholarship, Ross Barkley had the body of an adult at 13yrs, Jamie Vardy needed lower leagues to slowly develop yet Ronaldo was skinny and underweight until late.



Academy football often confuses current performance with potential performance. Players performing well here and now may not be the most talented whilst poor performers here and now might have greater potential to perform later. Potential talent is born, skill is nurtured. Basic levels of talent are required to be an elite athlete. Proper practice will never fail you and can make you elite, whilst talent alone will not compensate for a lack of practice.



Ski Slope Theory – Jay has been skiing for two years whilst Jake has never skied before. If both went to the top of the ski slope then Jay would ski down the best and fastest. However, if Jake practised for two years he may be much better than Jay due to hundreds of tiny factors (natural ability, practice, mentality, drive, watching of video, analysis of own performance etc.)

Bumble Bee Theory - According to aerodynamics a bumble bee should not be able to become airborne. Not only does it fly but changes direction beautifully and makes amazing honey along the way. Talent does not always look how we want it to look.

CHRONOLOGICAL V BIOLOGICAL

There are dozens of excellent books on the market that discuss athletic development in detail. In short, the vital message to always remember is that a child's body can generally be biologically developed two years either side of his chronological age. Thus, a 13yr old can have the body of a 15 or 11yr old. This poses obvious problems with selection of players and assessing current performance throughout youth ages. Although there are certain indicators, there is no crystal ball to predict how a child will develop physically due to the numerous variables along the journey. As a result, coaches must have plans in place to cater for all players. For example, a late developer may need to play down an age group or be put in 1v1 practices against a player that he won't be physically completely dominated by all of the time, resulting in low confidence and efficiency. Whereas an early developer will often get success from physical advantages thus he will need to ensure his technical ability is proficient enough by the time players catch him up physically. He may need to play up an age group to ensure his physical advantages are not the sole reason for his success.



YOU CANNOT HAVE A MILLION POUND DREAM WITH A MINIMUM WAGE WORK ETHIC

Stephen C Hogan



PART TWO: OUTPLAYING

In my first book, **Developing An Elite Coaching Philosophy: In Possession**, I briefly outlined the significance of coaching players to dominate 1v1 situations. This section will look at this in detail and outline exactly how to build players who are efficient in 1v1 situations. The process can be put in place at any age, but works most efficiently starting early with the foundation ages (6-11) as it builds the technical and physical foundations for the future. These golden ages are where the physical and ball literacy can become patterned and the technical/physical 'toolbox' underpins everything. Although, with this said, I have worked with first team players who have invested in it and seen enormous improvements. It is an area of the game that, in my opinion, is still misunderstood by a lot of people. One of the main reasons for this is because in the early stages of experimentation for the player, it looks messy. It leads to turnovers and being caught on the ball as they begin to figure it out. It looks like you are creating dribblers. It doesn't look smooth and it takes patience. This 'dribbling' concept is a complete misinterpretation, hence this section of the book will aim to break down how the process evolves and why.

THE FUTURE GAME

The game is constantly changing at the elite level. As coaches we must move with this otherwise we are spending years preparing players for an English exam through teaching Maths lessons. The core principles of the game are the same as they were decades ago, however, the increase in resources, education and athleticism has influenced specific changes. One could write a full book alone on these, however, I feel these are the significant ones:

- Without the ball, according to heat maps, teams defend on average 12 yards deeper than in 2009
 - There are much longer defending phases on average
 - Average ball recovery is much deeper
- Teams block the centre of the field faster, and in a more organised and compact way than ever before

- Due to factors such as increase in athleticism and more organised coaching, players recover behind the ball faster and are more compact and organised than ever before
- A Champions League player has to be able to play in 'the jungle'

There are generally three defensive blocks that an opposition can be in, regardless of the system or formation:



Wherever a team defends on the field, whatever block they setup in, there is now very limited space. Anyone just needs to watch any Premier League, international or Champions League game to see this. To further the point of creating players who can play in this jungle and chaos, let's look at the best or most expensive players currently in world football: Messi, Ronaldo, Pogba, Gareth Bale, Gonzalo Higuain, Luis Suarez, James Rodriguez, Kevin De Bruyne, Angel Di Maria, Zinedine Zidane, Oscar. Notice the pattern. Every one of these play within the block and are game changers. They are efficient players in the final third who can outplay opponents to create.

In your team, if you had eleven technicians who could pass, receive, outplay, stay on the ball under pressure and twist and turn to unlock or retain – you can mould those eleven players into what you want tactically. If you have players who cannot retain possession under pressure, then being a tactical genius will have limited impact. You can be the most tactically astute coach on the planet but the individual parts make your ideas function. It's not about the coach, it's about the players. Make the sessions for the players.

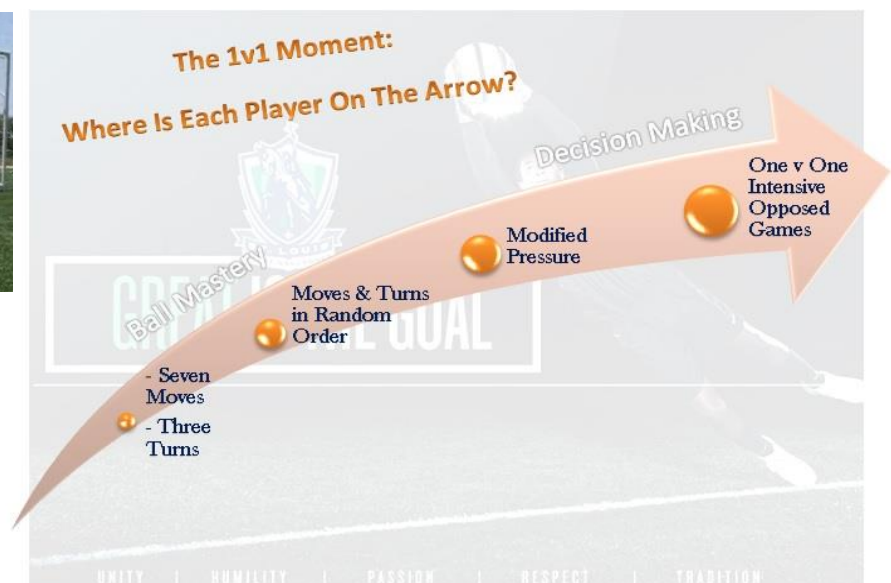
OUTPLAYING

Recognising these game changes, every position on the pitch now requires technical excellence. Given the limited space, a high percentage of the game is under pressure with over 80% of receiving situations at the elite level being pressure behind/side. Because the intensity and speed of the game is so high and teams are extremely well defensively organised, there are not always immediate solutions for the player on the ball. In an ideal scenario, players would always have time and space but that is not reality at the top level. For the situations where the player on the ball has no solution, if he does not have an ability to stay on the ball then what does he do? Give possession away. Thus, if the statistics tell us that the majority of the game is under pressure and that pressure predominantly comes from behind, and even in the situations when players do receive in space they are pressed

quickly; then players have to be able to deal with this 1v1 pressurised situation. The Spanish and South American players are particularly adept at receiving under pressure and using their body to stay on the ball. Outplaying an opponent does not just refer to taking an opponent on and going past him, to being skilful and performing tricks. Outplaying is getting the better of your opposing player and incorporates a lot of elements; the use of the body, the position of the arms, twisting and turning and safe manoeuvres to get out of trouble. In the majority of occasions, a player outplays to find a pass, not to dribble. He outplays to retain possession; it is a solution to a frequent problem. Watch all of the top players in the world, it's the common trait. The teams who have the highest possession statistics also have the highest 1v1 outplaying FREQUENCY and EFFICIENCY too. You cannot have collective possession without high level individual possession. Possession is not just one and two touch football as that one touch pass is not always on. Therefore, if you are a coach who wants to dominate the ball then you must invest in players who can outplay an opponent. If you don't then you are missing a huge piece of the jigsaw and end up having teams with a high percentage of possession and little penetration. It must be recognized that outplaying looks different for each position. A striker's outplaying technique(s) will predominantly be pressure behind to hold the ball up or twist and turn in the box. A defender's will likely be pressed from the front thus shaping up to play to a full back and cutting inside to step in. A deep lying midfielder's would likely be pressed from behind. When developing a player who can outplay, I personally use the following arrow:



This begins on the left hand side with simple but efficient moves that are all fake passes or turns to get out of trouble; drags, cuts and chops. Practicing 7 moves 1,000 times is better than practicing 1,000 moves 7 times. The next stage is mastering the specific moves but in a random order so that the player is building reactionary techniques rather than processed, robotic patterns. Flexibility and improvisation is the end goal, thus this stage is key to ensuring it does not become programmed responses. The next stage is modified pressure where the defender is passive – here the player builds in moving the defender, the distances, the use of the body and arms whilst still getting success through technique. The latter stage is fully opposed 1v1 games, usually with a direction or goal and added player(s). Every player is somewhere different on this arrow and it is down to the coach to ensure they get the specific work they need in accordance to this. Unfortunately, every



player cannot just be expected to be efficient on the right hand side of it. If a player does not have the tools to dominate an opponent then putting him in fully opposed one v one drills will make him get to the end of the arrow slower. Thus, just running a 1v1 exercise for players will not create what is intended. Similarly, a player who can train higher up the arrow needs to be moved on and challenged appropriately. The skill from the coach is not just recognizing where each player is at but making the players understand where they are. The only way they will climb the ladder is through practice.

The best players constantly learn from each other, even at the highest level. Coutinho speaks about the influence Joe Allen had on him when he signed at Liverpool *'I work with Joe sometimes to see how he uses his body to protect the ball. He is amazing at it.'* One of the world's most creative players in Coutinho looking at what he can learn from Joe Allen. When Coutinho was omitted from the Brazil squad at the World Cup, this was his response *'I will use this anger to push myself to my limits. I watched how Luis (Suarez) was a maniac in training. At this point my body and mind feels like clay. I will mould it the way I envision and I will use my fire to make it harder.'*

A question I get asked a lot is about the relevance of ball mastery and Coerver work. For me, ball mastery is important but it comes earlier at 5-8 years or at a stage when the player is at the bottom of the arrow. If they have the technical proficiency to shift and move the ball then they only need to be lower down the arrow for maintenance. Spending too much time there is clearly not harmful but the player could be challenged and improving in another area of his game rather than continuing to master techniques that he already has. Maintenance is an important part of technique though. Johnny Wilkinson used a brilliant analogy in his first book *My World* (one of the best I have ever read):

'I see technique as a jigsaw. Every time I practise I put the pieces together and the jigsaw looks great. Then, every night, the jigsaw box gets shaken up a little. When I come back to practice the next day, the pieces are out of place a little so I spend some time putting them back in. The problem is, the longer I don't practice, that jigsaw gets shaken up more and more.'

This is a brilliant analogy and phenomenal way of viewing technique and practice. An important point to note is the amount of first team players that say *'I wish I had worked on this when I was younger'*. For me, it should be a staple part of every single development programme in the world, even if it's just for 15-20 minutes every session. Instead, some people who apparently are 'pioneering' academy leaders with prestigious reputations, seem more passionate about bleep test scores, whether PMA is updated, hitting the big men, can we go over the (questionable) high press, whether or not the 11 year old is a good 'shape and size', how big his dad is and/or telling subs to walk off at young ages to drain the minutes. By the way, that last sentence could easily have been multiple pages...

DEVELOPING THE MOVEMENT

In addition to dominating their opponent with the ball, players must be able to dominate them without it too. The movement is a key part of individual development. A track athlete like Usain Bolt works for four year cycles in many areas of development to gain a hundredth of a second. Rather

than obsessing over a speed programme, footballers can gain over a second through intelligent movement. Let's look at some key statistics I have gathered:

- The average ball in play time is 60-70 mins in the Champions League
- The average Champions League player is on the ball for 60-90 seconds per game
- If team has 70% of possession then for 48 mins a player is looking for it

The individual movement principles to dominate an opponent can fall into several categories:

Occupy space out the eyeline

Standing out of the eyeline of opposing players, on the shoulders, constantly looking for angles and space. The distance from the ball is key; players should constantly be thinking '*by the time that ball reaches me, can the defender intercept it or can my first touch take me forward?*' The closer you are to the ball the smaller the distance can be, the farther away the bigger.

7:1 movements

Alex Inglethorpe introduced me to this principle at Liverpool. On average, the top players receive the ball every seven movements they make. For example, a winger may run in behind to come short and not receive, he may jump inside, he may drift out to the line, he may drop down the line if centre mid is pressed etc. By building a mentality with players of 7:1 movements, they do not get impatient when showing and not receiving it. It teaches them to constantly be looking and creating space and being patient doing so. This will include double movements which are explosive (running way to receive to feet and showing feet to spin in behind).

Arrival movements

These are usually slow and drifting as opposed to quick double movements like above. These start away from the ball and drop, showing high to low movements, to receive from deep. The timing of these is important and improves through constant practice. For me personally, these are the key to developing a positional game and dominating the ball.

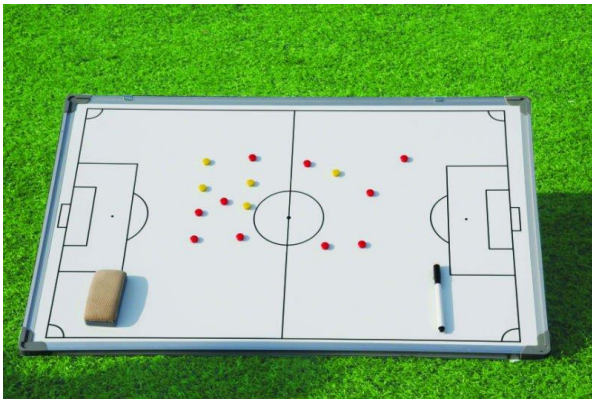
Individual dominance is not an inherited trait. It can be taught, nurtured and developed through the right process.

Question For Youth Coaches:

Are your games being decided by you or your players? Are your games being won by pressing triggers, traps, exposing the opposition's weaknesses, opposition's mistakes OR individual moments of technique? It's easy to coach a youth team to be efficient, the true LONG TERM coaching comes in developing individual quality.



PART THREE: SESSION EXAMPLES



- Simplicity is key
- Replicate the game
- Keep it specific
- Give them repetitions of what they need
- Give them consistent messages
- Enjoyment is sustainable

FOR COACHES:

Elite individual development is extremely difficult to fulfil if the support structure around the player is not conducive to optimise that talent. It is my firm belief that to optimise individual development, the collective style is imperative. The game model which the team plays in must bring out the best qualities of the individual. The system, style and formation must be built around the individuals, not the other way around. For example, if a team has no full backs but abundant centre backs then back three may be the logical choice. Do not force one to play full back. If the team has two good strikers, do not force one to play wide to suit the 4-3-3 model that the coach wants to play. Formational changes do not mean that the style of play has to change. These statements, I would like to think, are common sense but individual development must really be put under the microscope. If the games are based around the players and their individual qualities then training sessions should also be. Sessions must frequently have a large volume of minutes dedicated to achieving the desired collective style and game model, however, in my experience, time should also be dedicated to individual coaching. This does not necessarily mean pulling out individual players to work one to one, it can be done in so many ways.

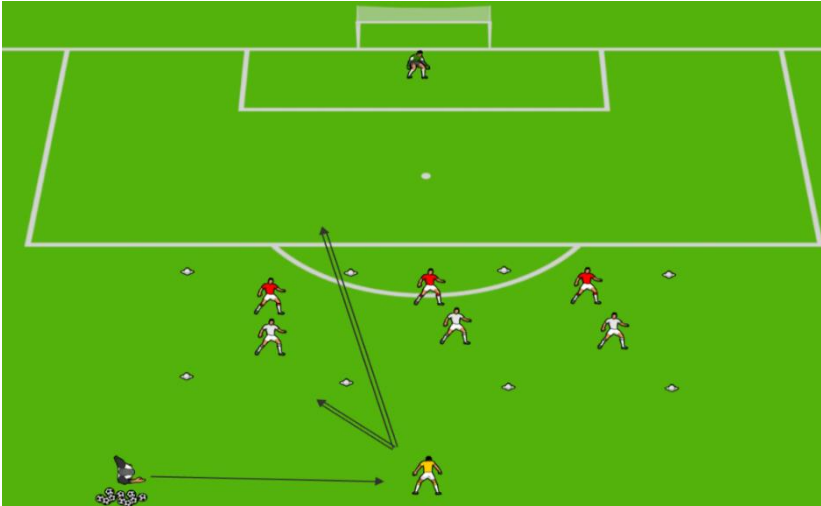
As one example, if your best player is a striker and your session is playing from the back, normally, you would start from the GK in a phase of play, small sided or full 11v11 game. The GK will build and you work with the back four, midfield etc to establish specific movement patterns. Now, here your problem is that your best player is just working on pressing for the session and will receive very little individual development on what he needs. Does he need pressing? Of course, but ultimately, he will be judged on his finishing and ability to create. Thus, rather than pulling him out the session to work individually and he loses his tactical work, begin the phase with the back four squeezed to the edge. You throw a ball over the top and the striker finishes it – the GK then places the ball down and you work on your tactical element. Now, once play is developing, you can speak to the striker about his timing of movement to go in behind, first touch depending on the angle and pass, triggers to run in behind, type of finish in accordance with defender recovering or GK position; and ultimately now you work on playing from the back and achieve your collective objective whilst the striker gets 20-30 finishes at the same time. This is just one example of incorporating individual development within the collective structure.

VALUES ARE LIKE FINGERPRINTS. NOBODY'S ARE THE SAME BUT YOU LEAVE THEM ALL OVER EVERYTHING YOU DO

In terms of actual position specific or isolation work for individuals, here are some ideas and examples:

Isco

Efficiency of the 10



GENERAL

Coach feeds the 10, who receives and plays to any white. Each player must stay in their box; reds defend 1v1. Whites can bounce back to the 10 or combine together. If reds regain then they must play out to the 10 before attacking (whites now defend). Aim is to score goals – defenders cannot recover in behind boxes

LOOK FOR

Individual movement to dominate the opponent from whites/reds. Away to come short, short to spin in behind. Individual domination with the ball. Outplay opponent, twist and turn, pressure changes from front/behind/side, body work to protect 1v1. Combinations together to get in behind. Around the corner passes, set and spin, quick passes to get in behind etc.

WORKING WITH THE 10 – INDIVIDUAL EFFICIENCY TO CREATE

Constantly look for the movement of players. Can you recognise the moment they look to run in behind? Can you see the gaps? Can you see when they show to feet to give them their 1v1 early? Creative, improvised, unorthodox passing; slide, chipped, first time, delayed, safe side, varied weight & disguised to break the block

PROGRESSIONS

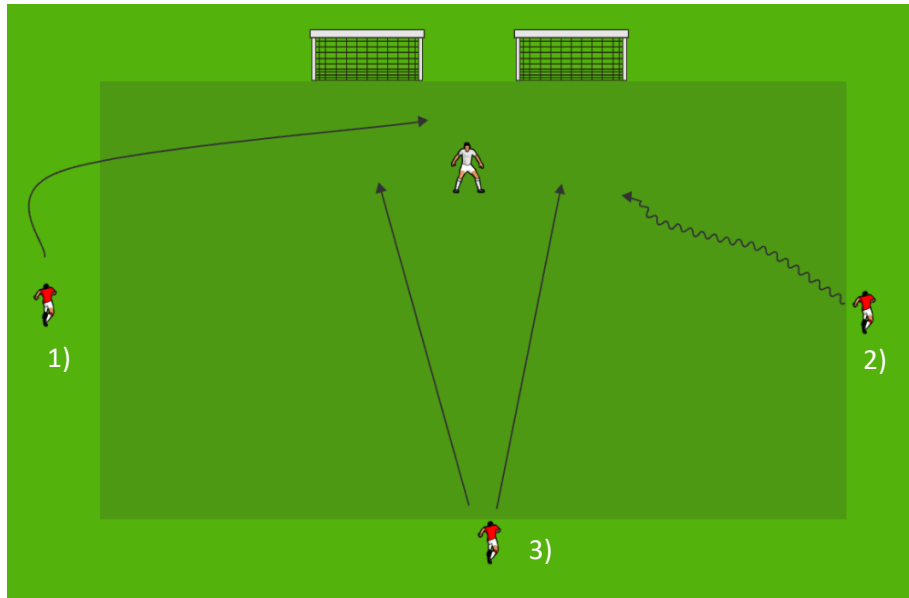
- Attackers can rotate boxes but defenders have to stay
- Defender can jump out and press the 10 (where is the overload now?)
- Use the practice as position and identity specific; three defenders who stay in the boxes and hit counter goals on the regain as opposed to changing to attack. Movements and efficiency of attacking front three (7,11,9) or front two if playing two up top. Specific movement patterns that relate to the game
- One defender can recover deeper than boxed area



- 1v1 in each box
- Boxes 7x7 minimum
- Boxes outside the 18 yard with the middle one central to goal
- Number 10 is in yellow and 6-10 yards away occupying various angles

Chiellini

An Italian Masterclass



- Defender in white starts in front of small target goals
- Target goals 3 yards apart
- Area size is around 20x20
- Three red players on outsides are attackers each with numerous balls

GENERAL

Centre back will defend five individual scenarios that all replicate game-realistic decisions he has to make. He defends one after another and then rests. Whilst he is resting, another centre back may come in and defend the same scenarios, should this be a position specific practice with more players

Player (1) acts as a left winger, gets a touch out of his feet and delivers a cross. Centre back must clear for distance and clear the boxed area (header, volley, half volley etc.)

Player (2) then dribbles 1v1 and tries to take on defender and pass into one of small goals. Defender must now execute attacker in front scenario and win the ball to clear

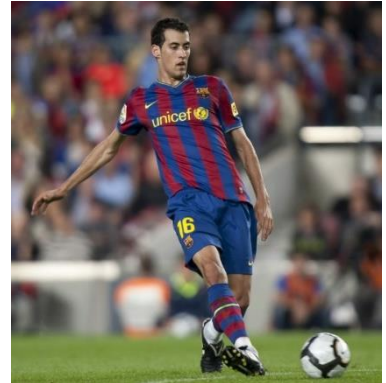
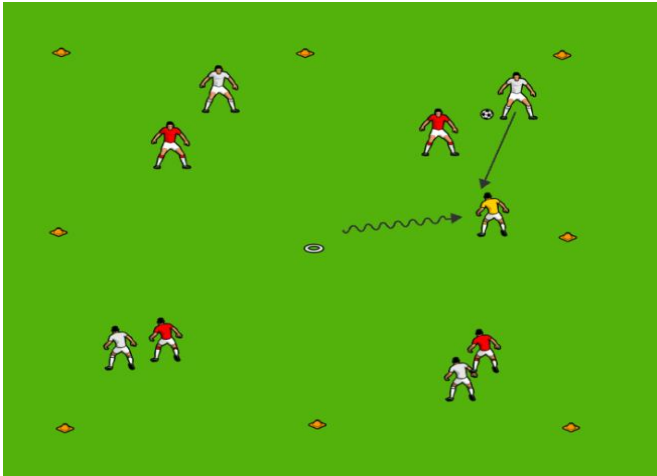
Player (3) then has a touch out his feet and tries to pass into smaller goals. Defender must read body cues and shape and intercept the pass. This replicates stopping a through ball by getting relevant distance between ball and goal

Player (1) then throws a ball high in the air and the centre back must win the aerial ball and head for distance

Player (2) now comes back into play and stands against the defender as player 3 passes a ball into his feet who tries to twist and turn to finish. Defender must stop the turn with attacker pressure behind and stop the goal.

Busquets

Spider In The Web



- 7x7 boxes (minimum) attached together with a flat marker in the middle to enable fluid play across it
- Yellow player is the central midfielder
- 1v1 in each box white vs red

GENERAL

1v1 in each box, one team retains possession against the other. The yellow player is the

spider in the web who connects the whole play; he is the Sergio Busquets. He can float into any square to control the tempo of the possession and create effectively a 5v4.

LOOK FOR

Find the free player. Individual movements from the players to create space. Individual domination with the ball to outplay opponent and retain possession. Outplaying techniques to find a solution when there is nothing on. Only outplay if you need to not because you want to. The priority is to find a free player

WORKING WITH THE SPIDER

He has to continually connect the play, control the rhythm and dictate the tempo. Constant small angles to receive, searching for space. Open body shape receiving to maximise awareness and continue possession sequence. The key is knowing when to SPEED UP and SLOW DOWN play. Anyone can coach one and two touch and make the game look as fast as possible but this is not realistic. If he is in open space and plays to someone who has no time on the ball, one touch play is inefficient and counterproductive to the function of possession. He must wait for players' movements to be open, slowing down the play to ALLOW movements to develop; this is key. If pressed, then outplay or play one touch. Taking that extra pause to see what develops is a huge part of developing control. The key is coaching the way in which the deep lyer finds space, looks for space, plays into/away from pressure, delays his decisions for movements, outplays if pressed and displays a high level of technique with various passing surfaces and disguise. The setup can be completely counter-productive if it purely focuses on building the speed and intensity; the only real benefit of this is impressing uneducated watchers. The real game is not played at one speed.

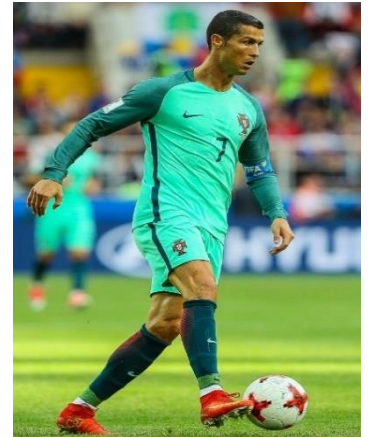
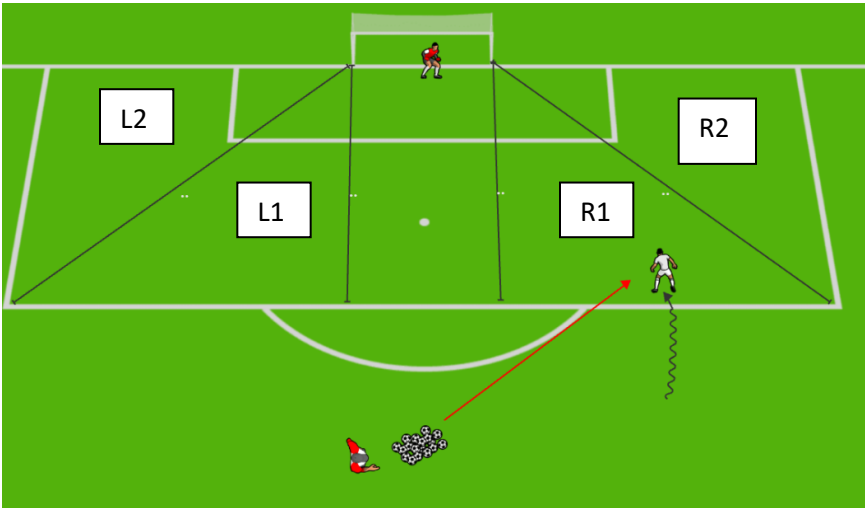
PROGRESSION

-Add in two goals either side of the box. The players can now look to run in behind and the spider in the web can add in final pass efficiency to his game

-Bring in goalkeepers and bigger goals to emphasise final third efficiency

Ronaldo

Multi Zone Finishing



- Penalty box split into four triangles. Line comes out from posts to corner of box and vertically to edge of box
- Lines done with flat markers
- Lots of balls needed with coach (red) outside the D

GENERAL

I took this session from Rene Mulensteen at Manchester United who used it with Ronaldo. The focus was to give him repetitions of finishing from various areas of the box. Rene highlighted the important of scoring 'ugly' goals as well as beautiful ones. *'Don't try place every shot in the corner, you see many hard shots go through GK's legs or in off his body so get used to just hitting the target'*. It's a great exercise for realistic reps, building confidence and efficiency. The penalty box is split into four sections; right one, right two, left one and left two. Striker starts outside the box and the coach slides a ground pass into R1. The striker runs on and finishes replicating playing on the shoulder of the centre back and having to finish early-five reps each zone

LOOK FOR

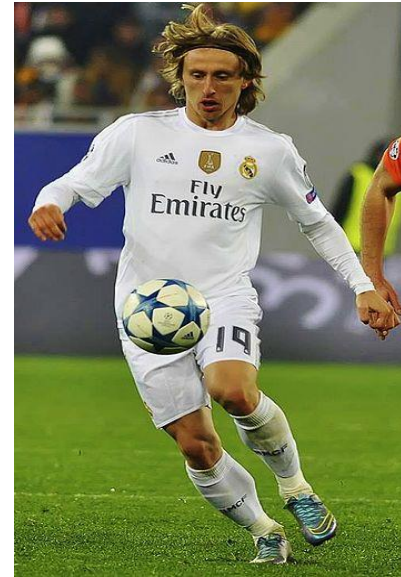
- Different types of finish; outside/inside, near post, curled (Henry), across GK, high, react to GK's position
- Top strikers in the world finish maximum 33% of their shots on goal so don't set targets that are unrealistic
- Over 80% of goals scored in the box are one/two touches – replicate this in training exercises
- In the 2nd zones, try to finish as early as possible as every millisecond delayed makes the angle more difficult or allows for recovery of defender

PROGRESSIONS

- Outplaying technique before finishing (cuts, chops, drags). Use disguise and try to have a maximum of two touches
- Build up the data. Film or record scoring and percentages and over a long period assess the stronger/weaker areas of the striker's finishing. Where does he like scoring from? Where does he need more repetition? What areas of the box is he efficient in?

Modric

Magic Off The Turn



- Requires a bag of balls, five mannequins, four cones, two smaller goals and a large goal

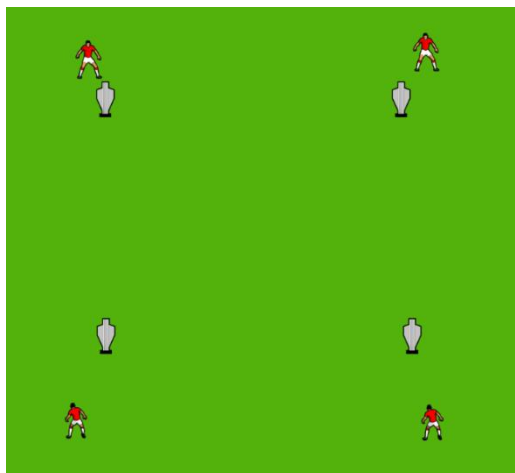
GENERAL

The coach starts with the balls in a central position but later moves to left and right (representing two centre backs in possession). If it is with a smaller group of centre mids then they can replicate this by taking up centre back positions and the c.mid chooses which one he receives from each time. The central midfielder begins out of the eyeline of the mannequin and shows angles either behind or drops in front of the mannequin. This represents the opposition's striker dropping to a medium block; a common scenario the deep lying player will face. The coach feeds the midfielder after his angle where he must drop with an open body shape and face the following repetitions:

1. Open up back foot & play into the smaller goal (represents playing through the lines)
2. Open up & play across his body into other small goal (playing into 10)
3. Open up & play into the large central goal with a driven pass (playing into the nine)
4. Drive the next pass in between mannequins out wide. This represents a switch of play
5. Now play around the corner first time into the smaller goals.
Angle/body shape must be clever
6. Player now finds each target but passes delivered aerially thus they have to bring the ball down and react quickly (half volleys, side volleys, bouncing drives, volleys)
7. Finally, player must receive, use any outplaying move that is specific to them then hit each target

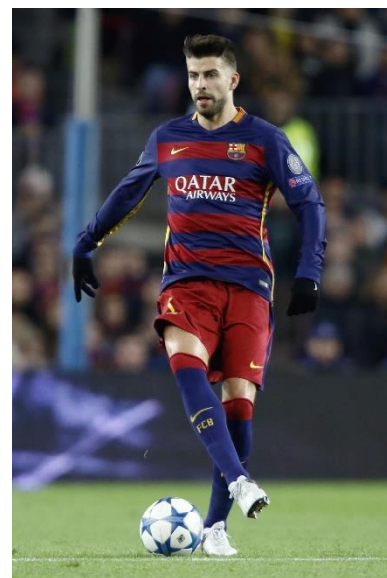
Pique

Stepping in OR Outplaying (3 parts)



PART ONE

Four centre backs stand behind four mannequins. Distance is relevant for age but around 15m. The first part is unopposed giving players reps of outplaying pressure to play forward. One ball starts with a player and before he plays to another centre back he must outplay the mannequin using the specific turns he would do in a game (Cruyff, drag, V turn etc.). Here players get technical execution of outplaying to then hit various lines in possession. The centre back horizontally



represents the circulation pass around the back line whilst the vertical players represent higher midfielders. Players must give angles inside and outside the mannequins so that centre back has to be aware of safe side. A progression; after any horizontal circulation pass, the centre back must step in with his first touch to break the line of the mannequin. Speed is vital in this exercise. Coach should be consistently assessing technique – fast ground passes, must hit every blade of grass, excellent receiving and efficient outplaying execution.

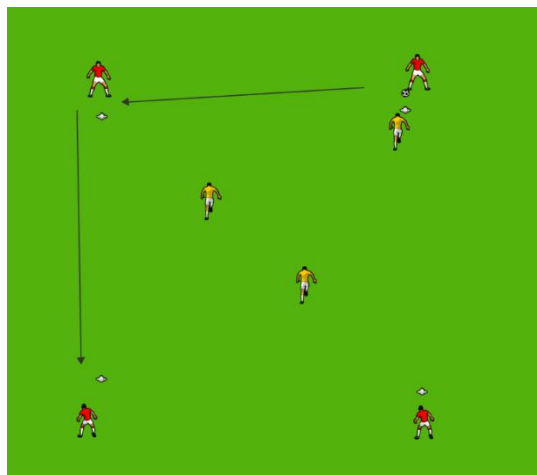


PART TWO

After the technical warm up, a central midfielder is now added in the middle of the square. He works on constant angles in relation to the ball. This is excellent for continual changing of body shape – challenge the CM to see three players at all times which ensures receiving open shoulders on the half turn. Centre backs now are building in order of priority in decision making:

- Play into 8 or 10 as a priority. If the angles are not on then play the CM. If that angle is not quick enough then step in with the ball to close your passing distances. If the pass was too heavy or mannequin was too close then outplay or circulate. Centre backs must understand this is the order. The unopposed practice builds cognitively the priority process. They should never be circulating or outplaying if there are free players higher just as they should not be playing the deepest midfielder if higher options are free.

PART THREE



The final part; bring in three players (or two more from previous section) requiring seven in total. The mannequins are replaced by cones. The back four players (reds) are maintaining possession whilst the three yellows must press together to steal the ball. The game is 4v3 but it is position specific. The centre backs always have an overload and a free player thus must be good enough to find or create it.

The key to the game is executing all techniques they have just worked on, under pressure. The decisions they make in games are put under the microscope here. In the above scenario, the centre back is in possession and the higher mids have been blocked, he is under pressure thus the correct option is to

circulate quickly before the other midfielder presses his centre back partner. This is the equivalent of a 10 and 9 jumping out to press in a game. The priority is always to play forward thus they are constantly assessing and deciding whether to play high, circulate, outplay or step in.

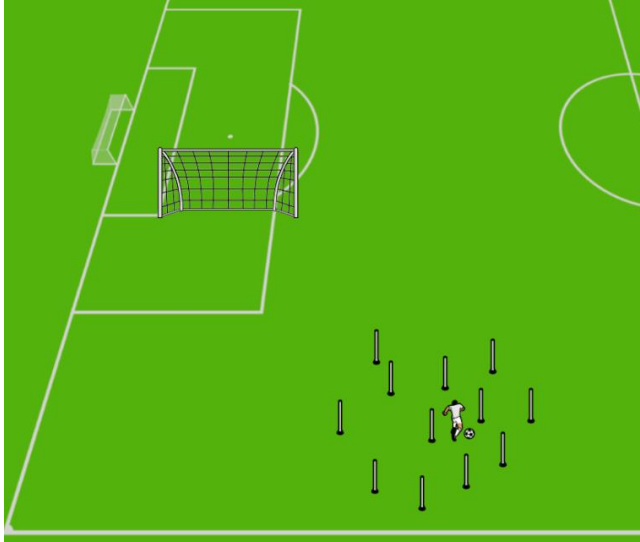
PROGRESSIONS

- The yellows have target goals that they can play into upon regaining possession. If they get a certain amount in an allotted time then the centre backs have a forfeit to complete. This keeps motivation for defending trio
- Add in a centre midfielder who must play inside the jungle of the midfielders
- Add in another defender which would make 5v4 in possession for the defenders/c.mid

I have found this session to be very good for creating the modern centre back who has to be comfortable on the ball. It develops REALISTIC and SPECIFIC techniques very quickly as well as relevant decision making. The speed at which players are progressed to the next part is crucial as the progressions cannot be rushed. If the centre back's techniques are not efficient enough then moving him on to part three will hinder progress. It is the same concept as the 1v1 arrow. Out of all the position specific or individual sessions I do, I have seen this practice really change players more than any other.

Robben

Enhancing The Maverick



GENERAL

The setup consists of random poles scattered, a series of balls and a bigger goal which is rotated to face the touchline. The right post of the big goal should be placed on the edge of the six yard box. This is functionally based on a winger.

The coach feeds a ball into the winger, who must receive and dribble in and out of the poles in various directions. This element is merely to work on quick feet, reaction to stimulus, outplaying turns, reactions and dribbling technique. After a specific time period (30 seconds usually), on the coach's call, the player bursts out of the poles and delivers a cross into the goal. After a rest period, which will be determined by the stage of periodisation in the week and year, the player repeats.

LOOK FOR

Dribbling setup:

- Place the poles on angles in the ground so that the dribbler has to use upper body movements and dipping of shoulders to change direction
- Coach can play various passes in the 30 seconds into the player so he adds receiving element

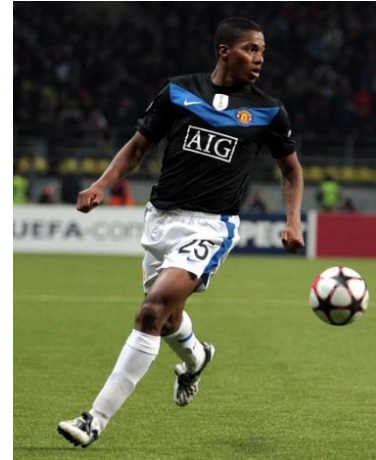
Range of cross:

- Whipped early and in a higher position on pitch (Beckham type cross hit net without bouncing)
- Driven at one height (laces, middle of ball, hit net without bouncing)
- If deep next to the touchline then stand up or pull back (lift over the goal to beat closest CB)
- Pull back turn onto other foot before delivering (FB has pressed)

The dribbling section can be observed on youtube by Nani working with Tony Strudwick for Code Red at Manchester United.

Full Backs

Playing Off The Circulation



GENERAL

For a full back, this scenario plays out hundreds of times in a season and many per game yet in my experience is rarely isolated and worked on. The coach begins with the balls, the yellow left back starts wide, the red player will be the opposition pressing winger and the white player will be the yellow's left winger. The coach has a touch out his feet and passes to the left back, on the coach's touch the red player can jump up to press. The coach represents a centre back who is circulating to the left back – it happens many times every game, every level.

DECISION MAKING

The full back receives and must deal with the pressure from the winger. The pressure will come from various directions depending on the opposition's game plan and stage of the game. The full back has to deal with all scenarios; being shown inside, being shown outside and the full press. Some solutions will include:

- Winger presses outside and is a short distance away, full back must take a touch inside first time and get his body across the winger.
- Winger presses and keeps his distance on the outside, full back needs to take a touch and pretend to use the winger with a fake pass, opening the body and hips then cutting inside and accelerating away
- Winger gambles inside, the full back needs to go to meet the ball and protect pressure side/behind and bounce back to the coach
- Winger sits off far, the full back opens his body and breaks the line with a pass in one touch
- Winger comes full press, the full back might bounce back first time then get high OR play around the corner to the winger
- At the same time, the winger needs to be working on his movements in accordance with the ball, pressure and defender. When does he jump inside (full back pressed and winger pressed outside)? When does he stay high and wide (no pressure on ball)? When does he drop down the line (full back under pressure). These combinations develop understanding between the full back and winger and are important elements of the partnership.



CONCLUSION

PLAYERS

From a player's point of view, it is absolutely imperative that you know this:

Football is dog eat dog. Not every coach you work under will want to develop you individually. You are easily dispensable on the football conveyor belt. Your journey is guaranteed to include extreme lows so be ready to react to them in a positive way. You must take control of your own destiny, control your path and create your own opportunities. Nobody owes you anything. You can increase your odds of becoming successful by having your own individual plan through knowing yourself. You must have a clear identity, on and off the field, and know what makes you unique. Have a trialist's mentality always and work daily to be better. Work smart and not just hard. Where are you going? Who are you surrounding yourself with to get there? Who are you speaking to that will enhance you? What is going to stop you getting there? What are you doing away from the field to enhance you as a person? Follow the advice in this book and you will give yourself the best chance of reaching your best. But, have a plan B...

COACHES

If I cast my mind back to school and think about who my favourite teachers were, they were inevitably the ones who got the best out of me. They had a personality that I liked and related to, which made me not want to let them down. Coaching football is the same, where players buy into the personality and knowledge of the coach. The best coaches bring out the best in their players. Development is about the learner, not the teacher. Taking a humanistic approach to developing the athlete is vital for long term success. Forget trying to adopt specific learning styles to optimise development (kinesthetic, visual, audio) as these have proven to be a myth. Copious amounts of recent research shows us that teaching young people according an 'individual learning style' does not lead to better results and is actually damaging long term. It can lead to a fixed approach and impair potential by preventing the player from adapting to various styles of learning; the real world. A single person can have numerous learning style preferences depending on the task and activity. As coaches, we must really work hard to understand the person and what drives them. This does not mean that a comfortable environment and soft culture is created, quite the opposite. Players need to be put in their place when the moment calls for it and to respect authority but this is much easier if they trust the hierarchy. The process is simple; create a culture through your own standards and behaviours, establish a game model that gets the best from the group and then work hard to develop individual relationships with the athletes.

PARENTS

Find a coach and club that you believe will deliver the best for your child. Football clubs are about people and culture, not facilities. When you have found a place you believe in, trust the staff. Do not get over involved and opinionated; trust the experts. You would not go into your child's school and tell the Maths teacher that their syllabus is wrong, the concept is the same. Encourage your child and reward hard work but leave the technical and tactical information to the people who do it for a living. **Make sure your child has his own plan, that he understands himself and has a clear direction he is working towards.** If he doesn't have this then find someone who can give him guidance on it. Having his own identity is crucial on and off the field. Each child must learn that success comes through hard work; this is a life lesson and a very important transferable skillset. Make sure that life does not solely revolve around football and encourage other interests.

TRAINING SPECIFIC

Tim Lees

This comprehensive dossier provides methods on how to design, enhance and create individual development.

Contained in it is an examination of the principles involved. This is then rationalised by some examples of professional academy and first team sessions with full images and diagrams of explanation.

The manual is split into three parts and includes:

Part One: Planting The Seeds

The principles of creating an environment for individual development to flourish

Part Two: Outplaying

Outplaying principles for 1v1 situations with and without the ball

Part Three: Session Examples

Session plan samples for various positions and profiles